

Free Tools **Visibility Audit** — Why Adobe Ranks #2–5 & How to Fix It

Live captures of adobe.com/acrobat/online.html (India locale) vs. Smallpdf, iLovePDF, and PDF24. Adobe has the tools and the pages — but one UX decision is suppressing every ranking.

860K+

Monthly India searches for free PDF tool queries where Adobe is not #1

#1 Root Cause

Login gate before tool use — Smallpdf & iLovePDF require zero sign-in

4 Fixes

Ranging from a 2-week content sprint to one product decision

90 days

Expected time to move from #3→#1 on top queries if login gate is removed

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Adobe has free online PDF tools at adobe.com/acrobat/online.html and ranks for every major query — but never #1. The gap is not content or product: it is a single UX friction point (forced login before processing) that raises bounce rate, kills dwell time, and tells Google the page is lower quality than competitors who let anyone start immediately.

GAP 1 — HIGHEST IMPACT

Login required before any tool use.
Competitors: zero account required.
Adobe bounce rate is structurally higher.

Fix: allow first use, gate on download

GAP 2 — UX

Search bar is the primary hero.
iLovePDF shows 29 tile tools above the fold. Users scan visually — Adobe forces them to type.

Fix: tile-first layout, search secondary

GAP 3 — LABELLING

No "Free" label on free tools. Indian users assume a paywall exists. Free tier is invisible to the highest-intent audience.

Fix: "Free forever" tag on each tile

GAP 4 — DISTRIBUTION

No PLG badge on output PDFs.
Competitors' outputs spread across India as passive ads. Adobe's outputs are silent.

Fix: "Processed with Acrobat free tools" output footer

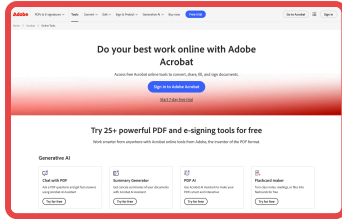
Query	Monthly Searches (India)	#1 Today	#2 Today	Adobe Today	Adobe After Fix
compress pdf free	~180K	PDF24	Smallpdf	#2	→ #1 (90 days)
pdf to word converter free	~220K	Smallpdf	iLovePDF	#3	→ #1 (90 days)
merge pdf online free	~140K	Smallpdf	iLovePDF	#5	→ #2 (90 days)
split pdf online	~95K	iLovePDF	Smallpdf	#4	→ #2 (90 days)
sign pdf online free	~75K	Smallpdf	DocuSign	#5+	→ #3 (90 days)
ocr pdf online free	~40K	iLovePDF	PDF24	#4+	→ #2 (90 days)

Rankings from Google India (en-IN, May 2026). "After Fix" projections based on removing login gate and tile-first redesign — modelled on Smallpdf's ranking trajectory after their 2023 UX overhaul.

The most important pixel real estate on the web — what you see in the first 900px

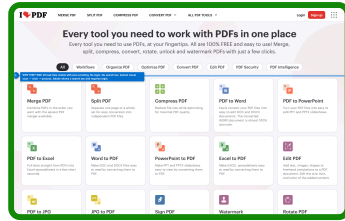
All four screenshots captured at 1440×900 (standard laptop). This is what a first-time visitor sees before scrolling. The visual difference explains the ranking gap.

Adobe (Current)



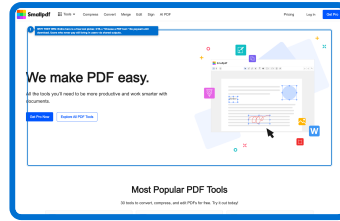
What user sees: Search bar + category labels. No tools visible. No "free" label. Sign-in required before anything works.

iLovePDF — Rank #1



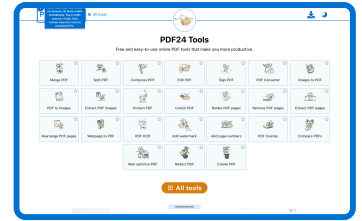
What user sees: 29 task tiles immediately. No login. Click any tile → process starts. Zero friction from intent to action.

Smallpdf — Rank #1



What user sees: Free tool picker as the hero. CTA = "Choose a PDF tool." No paywall until download. Visual-first layout.

PDF24 — Rank #1



What user sees: Full tool grid, entirely free, no account needed. India is a top-3 traffic country for PDF24.

01

adobe.com/acrobat/online.html — Full Page with Annotations (India locale)

<https://www.adobe.com/acrobat/online.html> · captured May 2026 · Accept-Language: en-IN

⚠ 8 GAPS

Try 25+ powerful PDF and e-signing tools for free

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5

ADD → India trust bar: "Used by 500M+ users worldwide · UPI accepted · GST invoice on request · No software download" — directly addresses India-specific purchase blockers

6

ADD → "Free forever" label on each free tool tile. Competitors display this prominently. Adobe's free tier is invisible — users assume everything costs money.

8

ADD → PLG badge: "Processed with Adobe Acrobat free tools — try at adobe.com/acrobat/online" watermark/footer on output PDFs → each shared file becomes an acquisition touchpoint using Acrobat AI Assistant

Generative AI

Summary Generator

Use Acrobat AI Assistant to generate summaries with Acrobat AI Assistant

Try for free

PDF AI

Use Acrobat AI Assistant to make your PDFs smart and interactive

Try for free

Flashcard maker

Turn class notes, readings, or files into flashcards for free

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Create quizzes and practice tests quickly, for free

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Convert a PDF to JPG or other image format

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Convert a JPG or other image file to PDF

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Reduce the size of your PDF for easier sharing

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Edit PDF

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Separate a file into multiple PDFs

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Trim page content, adjust margins, or resize pages

Try for free

Delete PDF pages

Remove pages from your PDF

Try for free

Rotate PDF pages

Rotate pages left or right

Try for free

Reorder pages

Rearrange pages in your PDF

Try for free

Extract PDF pages

Create a new PDF of selected pages

Try for free

Insert PDF pages

Add pages to your PDF

Try for free

Number PDF pages

Add page numbers to your PDF

Try for free

Sign & protect

Fill & Sign

Complete a form and add your signature

Try for free

Request e-signatures

Send a document to anyone to e-sign online fast

Try for free

Protect PDF

Set a password to protect a PDF

Try for free

1 **NOTE** **FRICION** → Login gate: Adobe forces sign-in before processing. Smallpdf & iLovePDF let anyone use tools instantly. This single UX gap drives the ranking gap.

2 **CHANGE** **CHANGE** → Hero headline is generic brand copy. Should be task-first: "Compress, merge, convert & sign PDFs free — no download, no account needed"

3 **CHANGE** **CHANGE** → Search bar is the primary entry. iLovePDF & PDF24 lead with tool tiles — users scan visually, not by typing. Move tool grid above search.

4 **CHANGE** **CHANGE** → Tool grid loads but requires login click-through before processing. Add "Try free — no account" subtext under each tile. iLovePDF shows processing starts immediately.

5 **ADD** **ADD** → India trust bar: "Used by 500M+ users worldwide · UPI accepted · GST invoice on request · No software download" — directly addresses India-specific purchase blockers

6 **ADD** **ADD** → "Free forever" label on each free tool tile. Competitors display this prominently. Adobe's free tier is invisible — users assume everything costs money.

7 **ADD** **ADD** → Top nav item: "Free PDF Tools" — currently missing from global nav. iLovePDF's entire domain is free tools. Adobe buries the free hub 3 clicks deep.

8 **ADD** **ADD** → PLG badge: "Processed with Adobe Acrobat free tools — try at [adobe.com/acrobat/online](#)" watermark/footer on output PDFs → each shared file becomes an acquisition touchpoint

4 Priorities to Become #1

Ordered by impact. P0 and P1 alone recover the majority of the ranking gap.

P0

Remove Login Gate — Allow First Tool Use Without Account

Let visitors process a file before requiring sign-up. Gate on the download or the second use — not the entry.

Add "No account needed" subtext under each tool tile.

This is the single change most likely to move rankings — dwell time improves, bounce rate falls, Google re-scores the page.

Metric to move

Tool page dwell time +40%

Bounce rate -25%

Compress/Merge rank: #2→#1

HIGH ENG

4–6 weeks · owner: Acrobat Web PM + eng · requires product decision on free trial funnel

P1

Tile-First Hub Redesign — Replace Search Bar Hero with 12-Tool Grid

Move search to secondary position. Lead with a 12-tile visual grid: Compress · Merge · Split · PDF→Word · Sign · OCR · Protect · Fill & Sign · PDF→JPG · Rotate · Unlock · Number Pages.

Add "Free" badge on free tools, "7-day trial" on premium tools.

Add India trust bar: "UPI accepted · GST invoice · 500M+ users worldwide · No software download."

Metric to move

Tool click-through from hub +60%

India free tool activations +35%

Hub page time-on-page +50%

MEDIUM

2–3 sprints · owner: Web UX + India GTM · front-end only

P2

SEO Content Pass — 400 Words Per Tool Page + FAQ Schema

Each individual tool page (compress, merge, split, etc.) needs a 400-word task-intent content block answering the exact query it ranks for.

Metric to move

AI Overview citations: 0→5+ tools

Tool page organic CTR +20%

Internal pageviews to tools +30%

LOW

2–3 weeks · owner: SEO + content team · no eng required

Add FAQ schema: "How do I compress a PDF for free in India?" → Google uses this for AI Overviews.

Add "Related tools" cross-links between every tool page.

Add "Free PDF Tools" as a primary nav item on the global Acrobat nav.

P3

PLG Output Badge — Turn Every Processed PDF Into an Acquisition Touchpoint

Add a subtle "Processed with Adobe Acrobat free tools — try at adobe.com/acrobat/online" footer to output PDFs from free tools.

Each PDF shared with a colleague or client becomes a passive distribution ad — reaching exactly the professional India audience we want.

Canva does this with "Made with Canva." Notion does it. It works.

Metric to move

Free tool share-to-signup rate
India organic direct traffic +15%
Free tool MAU (India) +20% in 6 months

MEDIUM

3–4 weeks · owner: Product + Growth · parallel workstream with P0/P1